

PRIZED CATCH:
Rao with one of
his tarantulas



Here Comes the Spider-man

A passionate forest official has an uncanny knack for locating rare, previously unrecorded spiders

■ **By Sandeep Unnithan**

It happened four years ago but K. Thulsi Rao remembers like it happened just yesterday. The assistant conservator of forests was trekking through the Nallamalai forest in the Eastern Ghats in search of tree frogs when he saw a hairy ash-grey, velvet-skinned spider slowly emerge from the bark of a dead tree. It was a surprise, even for someone who took pride in his ability to provide a checklist of all the flora and fauna simply by looking at the structure of a forest. It was unlike anything he had ever seen.

Sure enough, research revealed it to be a previously unrecorded tarantula species. A shy but lethal, palm-sized ambush predator that preyed on lizards, insects and small snakes, injecting them with deadly venom before sucking out their body fluids. This vampire of the deep forest was named *Poecilotheria nallamalai* but would be only the first of four serendipitous arachnid discoveries that this soft-spoken 54-year-old conservator would make in Vizag's Nagarjunasagar Andhra Pradesh Tiger Reserve.

Yet Rao, who has left his family behind in the city over 200 km away while he spends time in the forest, is extremely guarded in speaking about his eight-legged



discoveries. And for good reason.

Most of the spiders are so rare, so exotic, that poachers would fork out hundreds of dollars for each of them. There is the *Tmarus srisailamensis*, the tiny greyish black spider that lives in crevices on the forest floor; the amphibious spiders of the Lycosidae family that descend in an air bubble, scuba-diver like, before grabbing passing fish, pulling them out of the water and devouring them on the rocks. The *Phrinicus andhranensis*, resembles a spider-scorpion hybrid with arms that look like crab claws. The *Poecilotheria metallica*, an ornamental tarantula spider, also known as the peacock spider for its brilliant blue coat, was last spotted in the 19th century.

These spiders remained unknown to man mainly because no one penetrated the dense forests of the Eastern Ghats, one of the only five bio-diversity hotspots in the country. With a loss of their habitat, the spiders are as endangered as every other forest denizen. "Spiders are natural predators of crop pests. Develop farm lands with trees and they will guard your harvest," says the conservator, pulling a Nallamalai spider out of a customised tarantularium and taking him for a walk, like one would take a pet dog.